ENVIRONMENT

CREATE A CLIMATE FOR CHANGE

Progress has been made to protect the environment, but more needs to translate into action. India's climate goals also need technology and funds push

By Amarnath K. Menon



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Bhupender Yadav
Minister of Environment, Forests and Climate Change

WHAT'S DONE

- Increased coverage of protected areas for wildlife
- Developed single window integrated system, Parivesh, for transparent environment, forest, wildlife, CRZ clearances
- Streamlined process for grant of environmental clearances in less than 70 days
- Initiatives, reforms to reduce average time for grant of EC in all sectors

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Phase out harmful chemicals as per the accelerated schedule of the Montreal Protocol
- Attend Conference of Parties in Kunming, China in 2022 to adopt a Post 2020 Global Biodiversity Framework
- Reduce dependence on fossil fuels

CONCERN ABOUT PROTECTING THE environment is growing steadily, and major strides have been made in protecting forests and wildlife. But, in other areas, solemn rhetoric is often not matched with action. The ban in the use of single-use plastic is a stark case of failure in implementation. To set an example, the ministry, now led by Bhupender Yadav, last December organised an auction of e-waste to dispose of obsolete items like computers, printers, photocopiers. Its detailing of processes in dealing with hazardous wastes, including that from hospitals, offers some hope.

However, findings in the biennial India State of Forest Report (ISFR), 2021 have been contested. While the report admits that area under 'moderately dense forest' has declined by 1,582 sq kms, other additions apparently suggest that the country's forest cover is inching closer to the national forest policy and climate adaptation targets.

At the Climate Change Summit in Glasgow last year, India stated that dialogue must be converted into action. The country is well on its way to achieving its goals under Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs). At the summit, India set for itself new targets by 2030: producing 500 gigawatts renewable energy, meeting 50 per cent of its energy needs using renewables, reducing greenhouse gas emissions by one billion tonnes and decreasing the economy's carbon intensity to under 45 per cent. It has committed to reach net-zero emission levels by 2070.

All of this is ambitious, but may not be realistic. Effective action against climate change needs consistent flow of funds and technology, and industrialised nations have been unable to keep their promise made at Paris in 2015. Finding finance for developing low-cost climate technologies while reducing dependence on fossil fuels is a growing challenge. India has to do a balancing act. ■